The Scopes 'Monkey' Trial — Bryan and Darrow

Dayton, Tennessee · July 20, 1925 · seventh day of testimony · excerpt

Source: The World's Most Famous Court Trial: Tennessee Evolution Case (1925), available via archive.org.

In 1925 Tennessee passed the Butler Act, making it illegal to teach human evolution in public schools. The American Civil Liberties Union recruited high-school teacher John Scopes to challenge the law. The trial in Dayton became a national spectacle — radio-broadcast, press-saturated — between Clarence Darrow for the defense and three-time presidential nominee William Jennings Bryan for the prosecution. On the seventh day, Darrow called Bryan himself as a witness on biblical literalism. Scopes was convicted (later overturned on a technicality), but the cultural moment damaged the fundamentalist movement.

Connect: The Scopes Trial's fundamentalism-vs-modernism split echoes the 2nd Great Awakening (Class 14). How is 1920s religion different from 1830s religion?

Key Passages

Darrow questions Bryan on Jonah

DARROW: But do you believe He made them — that He made such a fish and that it was big enough to swallow Jonah? BRYAN: Yes, sir. Let me add: one miracle is just as easy to believe as another. DARROW: Just as hard? BRYAN: It is hard to believe for you, but easy for me. A miracle is a thing performed beyond what man can perform.

On the age of the earth

DARROW: Do you think the earth was made in six days? BRYAN: Not six days of twenty-four hours. … My impression is they were periods.

Bryan, on Darrow's purpose

BRYAN: The only purpose Mr. Darrow has is to slur at the Bible, but I will answer his questions … I want the world to know that this man, who does not believe in a God, is trying to use a court in Tennessee — DARROW: I object to that. BRYAN: — to slur at it, and while it will require time, I am willing to take it.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — change over time in 1920s culture: Identify ONE specific cultural tension the Scopes Trial reveals.

2. Why is the Scopes Trial often called a turning point in modernism vs. fundamentalism — even though Scopes lost?

3. Compare urban vs. rural responses to the trial.